

Profanity: The Command Line Instant Messenger

Profanity is a text based instant messaging application which uses Command line Interface (CLI), which beats many GUI (Graphical User Interface) applications of a similar nature. By virtue of having a CLI, Profanity is faster than any GUI, since it involves less effort as there's no fumbling between mouse and keyboard. The biggest advantage of Profanity is that the user can generate various scripts to multi-task.



Profanity is a command line chat application for the XMPP-Extensible Messaging Presence Protocol, which is packed with loads of features for typical user needs. In this article, we're going to explore some of its features.

Why prefer CLI when there's GUI?

There are plenty of instant messengers (IMs) available for all the three platforms, which provide loads of features. So what makes Profanity stand out?

The answer is that Profanity is one of the very few applications that uses the CLI (command line interface) instead of a GUI (graphical user interface).

In our daily life, we use GUI applications everywhere, and the users' expectations of the appearance of the software have grown dramatically over the past years. Newer frameworks focus on how best the UI can be pleasant without compromising on the functions of that particular software.

It is a perception that CLI applications are for geeks, hackers and systems admins, while typical users prefer GUI applications since the latter are much easier to work with. But Linux users can be exceptions to this, since they often use the CLI for installing, configuring and fine-tuning the operating system.

Both the CLI and GUI have their pros and cons, but the former is a much better option for many reasons, some of which are listed here.

1. CLI users need only the keyboard to work on and hence can perform tasks faster than GUI users who need to use the mouse as well as the keyboard. For a simple copy and paste operation, the CLI uses a single command whereas the GUI has to navigate through the source and target locations in the file system.
2. The CLI offers more control on the file and system than the GUI, like changing the user permissions (read, write and execute) and the ownership of a particular file.
3. Since the CLI is only used to perform tasks that require a few system resources, it is highly unlikely to be clogged or to freeze mid-task.
4. The CLI enables users to write scripts to perform a series of tasks, while the GUI supports multi-tasking for performing multiple tasks at the same time, but it doesn't beat the CLI's performance.

Installation

Profanity is available for Linux, Windows and Mac. For now, let's look at how to install it in Linux machines. Separate installation instructions for Windows and Mac can be found at the Profanity website.

Profanity has been included on some of the major distributions such as Arch, Gentoo, Ubuntu, Open SUSE and Slackware. If your OS is not in the above list, then you can use the installation script found in the Profanity tar ball. When you run the installation shell script, it will take care of